Lyonchhen Jigmi Yoezer Thinley.

The theme of Seventeenth SAARC Summit is ***Building Bridges***. The theme is significant as it can be seen as an attempt to bridge the gaps created by uneven economic development and income distribution, the gaps in recognizing
and respecting the equality of men and women, the closing of space between intent and implementation. This Summit was seen as a push to boost the building of bridges among SAARC countries to establish an equitable SAARC region.

In this Summit, four agreements were signed which are SAARC Agreement on Rapid Response to Natural Disasters, SAARC Agreement on Multilateral Arrangement on Recognition of Conformity Assessment, SAARC Agreement on Implementation of Regional Standards, and SAARC Seed Bank Agreement. In addition, the **Addu Declaration** on the theme Building Bridges was issued on 11 November 2011, in the Addu Summit. The member states reaffirmed their commitment to peace, confidence building, liberty, human dignity, gender-based violence, democracy, mutual respect, good governance and human rights. They voiced their concerns over terrorism in all its form: trafficking, maritime piracy, environmental degradation and threats of
Climate Change. Further, the member states resolved to strengthen the institutional mechanisms of SAARC in order to bolster and enhance regional cooperation.

Eighteenth Summit: Kathmandu, Nepal, 26–27 November 2014

The eighteenth SAARC Summit was hosted by Nepal. It was held in Kathmandu during 26–27 November 2014. The Summit, however, began in the background of grim relation between India and Pakistan over cross-border firing, terrorism and ensuing diplomatic thaw in their relation. The SAARC countries however saw a need to reinvigorate and revitalize SAARC. Despite coldness between India and Pakistan, the SAARC Kathmandu Declaration upholds the theme ***Deeper Integration for Peace and Prosperity*****.** The Declaration underlined deepening of regional integration for peace and prosperity by promoting mutual trust, amity, understanding, cooperation and partnership. The countries pledged to cooperate in